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*Supporting narrated video (NV) demonstrations, high-speed video (HSV) clips, technical proofs (TP), and all past articles are available online at **drdavepoolinfo.com**. Reference numbers used in the articles help you locate the resources on the website.*

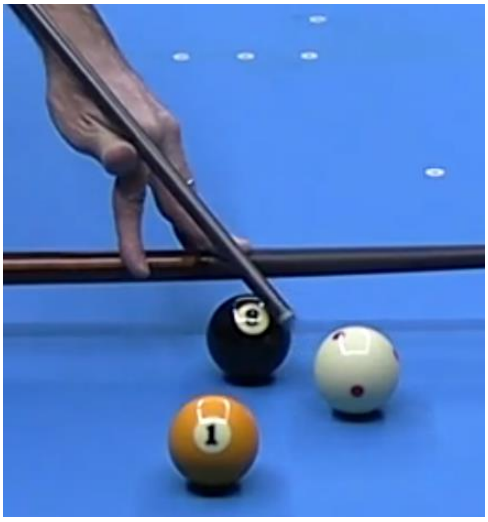
As Bob Jewett mentioned in a recent column, the World Pool Association (WPA) updated the official rules of pool for the first time in about 10 years! I recently posted an online video (**NV L.91**) that summarizes the major changes and shows game situation examples affected by the changes. I’ll share some of these examples below.

In the past, you were not allowed to lay your cue on the table for aiming and aligning purposes without having at least one hand in contact. This rule has now been relaxed. As shown in **Image 1**, there is nothing wrong with releasing the cue. The new rules now explicitly allow you to use your cue and any part of your body to aim and plan shots. Although, as demonstrated in the video, you are not allowed to mark the cloth with a chalked tip, so be careful how you handle the cue when the tip in contact with the cloth. It is also illegal to place a chalk or anything else on the rail as an aiming target.

Image 1 Cue on the table for aiming and aligning is now allowed

When using a mechanical bridge, the rules now make it clear that the cue must be supported by the head of the bridge. You are not allowed to use a hand bridge on top of the mechanical bridge head as shown in **Image 2a**. You are also not allowed to support a hand bridge on the handle of the mechanical bridge as shown in **Image 2b**. You are allowed to use two mechanical bridges, but the 2nd bridge must be supported by the head of the 1st bridge, and the cue must be supported by the head of the 2nd bridge.

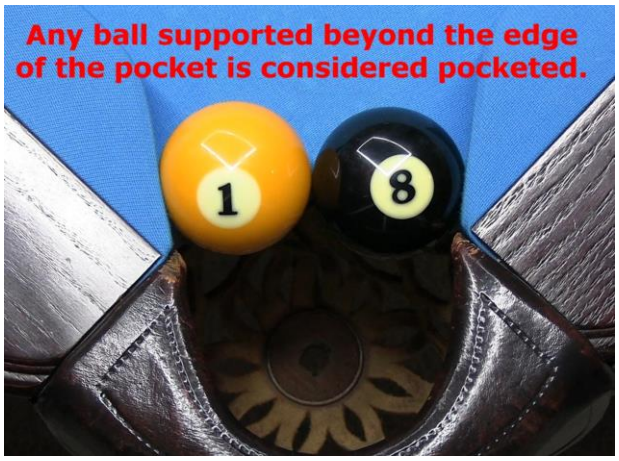
a) **hand bridge on head**



b) **hand bridge on handle**

Image 2 Illegal uses of the mechanical bridge

There are several rule clarifications concerning balls settling at the end of a shot. If a ball comes to rest close to the edge of a pocket, you must wait 5 seconds before shooting the next shot. If the ball falls during these 5 seconds, it is considered pocketed. If the ball falls after 5 seconds, it must be replaced as close as possible to the original location. Also, the rules now clearly state that if a ball is supported beyond the edge of the pocket, where it would fall into the pocket if supporting balls were removed, the ball should be pocketed. For example, the two balls in **Image 3a** are jammed in the back of the pocket opening. Because removing either ball will let the other ball fall, both balls should be pocketed. **Image 3b** shows another example where because there are so many balls in the pocket already, the 8 is being supported. But again, if the ball is hanging over the edge of the pocket and drops when supported balls are removed, the ball is considered pocketed. Obviously, balls should not be allowed to stack this high in a pocket; but if it happens, it is now clear what to do.



a) balls jammed in back of a pocket

b) a ball supported by balls in a full pocket

Image 3 Balls supported beyond the pocket edge are considered pocketed

The new rules make it crystal clear that if a foul call is uncertain, the benefit of the doubt always goes to the shooter. An example where this comes up is in determining whether a legal ball is hit first when there is a nearby obstacle ball. **Image 4** shows an interesting example of this, where the ball lines are perpendicular relative to a split-hit cue ball (CB) position. As demonstrated in the video, with a legal hit of the 8 first, the CB stops in place. And with an illegal hit of the 13 first, the CB also stops in place. Obviously, if you do not have slow-motion video replay, it can sometimes be extremely difficult to tell for certain which ball was hit first. In situations in this, it must be assumed that the 8 was hit first legally. And even when slow-motion replay is available, it still might be impossible to tell which ball was hit first since a lot can happen between the available frames of video. If it is not certain an illegal ball is hit first, the benefit of the doubt goes to the shooter and a legal shot is assumed.

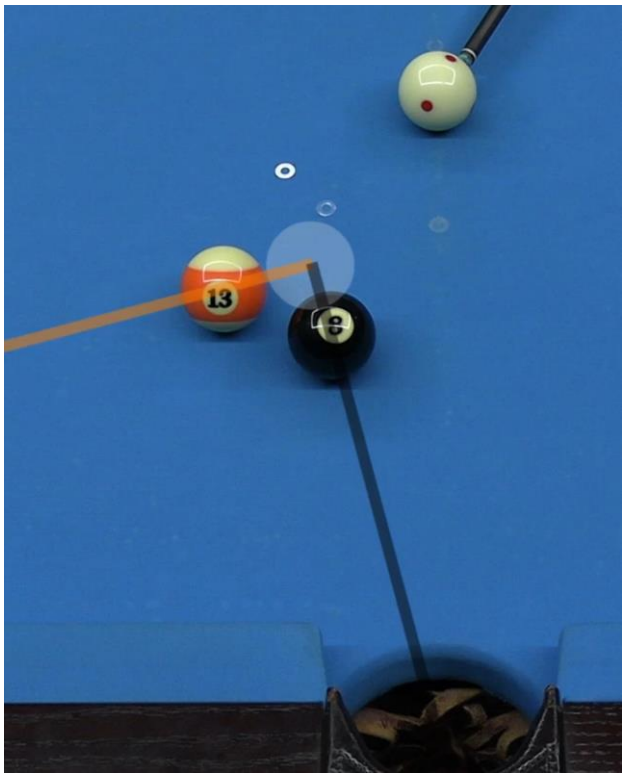


Image 4 Benefit of doubt of split hit uncertainty goes to the shooter

Another type of shot where clarifications were added to the rules are unintentional miscue scoops, where the CB leaves the playing surface. When a scoop is the result of an unintentional miscue during an attempted draw shot, the new rules specifically make it clear that these shots are not fouls, unless there is some other infraction. The video shows two examples from recent pro tournaments where the previous rules were not interpreted correctly, partly because the old rules were not clear or complete enough on this matter. These bad calls should not occur in the future.

In the previous rules, there was a regulation that allowed CB fouls only when referees were not available. This is common in league systems where players are not penalized for touching or moving an OB by mistake before, during, or after a shot. In these leagues, the opponent has the option to return moved balls to their previous locations after the inadvertent move. CB-fouls-only is no longer an option in the new WPA official rules of pool. Therefore, except when you have ball in hand, where you are allowed to place the CB without touching any other balls, you are never allowed to touch or move any ball with anything except using the cue tip with a single hit during a legal shot. In general, league systems should follow the official rules of pool, but this is one rule they might find challenging to embrace.

There are also new rules and regulations concerning the 9-ball break, 10-ball safeties, bank pool, one pocket, doubles play, racking, player-refereeing, and parasports events, so be sure to check out online video **NV L.91** for more information and examples. The video also demonstrates everything in this article and much

more. If you want to learn more about the new WPA official rules of pool, check out the links in the YouTube video description or on the "**pool rules**" and "**fouls**" resource pages at ***drdavepoolinfo.com***.

Good luck with your game,
Dr. Dave

normal video

NV L.91 – New WPA Official Rules of Pool … Learn About All the Changes

PS:

- I know other authors and I tend to use lots of terminology, and I know not all readers are totally familiar with these terms. If you ever come across a word or phrase you do not fully understand, please refer to the online glossary at ***drdavepoolinfo.com***.

Dr. Dave is a PBIA Master Instructor, Dean of the Billiard University, and author of the book: The Illustrated Principles of Pool and Billiards and numerous instructional DVD series, all available at: ***DrDaveBilliards.com***.